WEEKLY MEAL PLAN FOR BUSY FAMILIES: 7 DINNERS AND ONE SHOPPING LIST | TRILLION MAN OUTREACH
WHAT'S FOR EATS | PRINTABLE DINNER GUIDE

Weekly Meal Plan for Busy Families: 7 Dinners and One Shopping List | Trillion Man Outreach

Easy Weeknight Dinner Recipes

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Weekly Meal Plan for Busy Families: 7 Dinners and One Shopping List

By the Trillion Man Outreach kitchen crew Updated October 8, 2026

A meal plan does not have to be a color-coded spreadsheet. It just has to answer one question before 5 p.m.: what are we eating? Here is a ready-made week matched to how tired you will probably be each day, a combined shopping list and the 10-minute method for making your own.

The 10-minute planning method

Check the calendar. Practice night and late-meeting night get the easiest dinners.

Pick one slow cooker or dump-and-bake night for your busiest day.

Choose two no-brainer nights, like quesadillas or breakfast for dinner.

Check the pantry and freezer before writing the list.

Post the plan where everyone can see it so the nightly "what do you want?" debate ends.

A sample week

Monday: Slow cooker salsa chicken
with rice and tortillas. Start it in the morning. Make extra.

Tuesday: Chicken quesadillas
using Monday's leftovers. About 15 minutes.

Wednesday: Sheet-pan sausage and broccoli.
One pan, foil lined.

Thursday: Pantry pasta with white beans and spinach.
A 20-minute pot meal.

Friday: Breakfast for dinner.
Scrambled eggs, toast and fruit.

Saturday: Egg fried rice
with leftover rice and frozen vegetables.

Sunday: Quick chicken soup
from the last of the chicken, broth and frozen vegetables.

Recipes for most of these are on our
main recipes page
. See also
slow cooker dinners
and
sheet-pan dinners
.

Combined shopping list

Protein and dairy:
2 lb chicken breasts, 1 package cooked sausage, 1 dozen eggs, shredded cheese, parmesan, butter.

Produce and frozen:
broccoli, baby potatoes, frozen peas and carrots, frozen spinach, fruit, onions.

Pantry:
salsa, taco seasoning, black beans, white beans, marinara, pasta, rice, tortillas, broth, soy sauce, oil, bread.

Check what you already own first. A fifth jar of cumin is not a plan.

Plan for energy, not ambition

Put the easiest dinners on your worst days. If the week falls apart, swap two nights without guilt. For ideas, see
easy dinners for no-energy nights
. Cooking once and eating twice cuts both effort and cost, which helps your
cost per serving
.

Skip the planning

The
5:47 p.m. Rescue Kit
plans the week in one click based on how tired each day will be, builds the grocery list sorted by store section and prints a fridge sheet.

Let us take dinner off your plate

The Rescue Kit picks dinner by how tired you are. The Cheap Dinner Vault shows what each dinner costs.

Get the Rescue Kit

Get the Cheap Dinner Vault

Questions, answered

How far ahead should I plan dinners?

Five to seven days works for most families. Plan around your calendar and leave one

flexible night.

How do I plan meals when my schedule changes?

Keep two or three pantry or freezer dinners available so you can swap nights without a shopping trip.

Helpful outside resource

Pair your weekly plan with practical cost-saving ideas from MyPlate's healthy-eating-on-a-budget guide
.

Explore every dinner guide

Keep building your weeknight plan with these related guides. Each one covers a different part of getting dinner on the table.

5-Ingredient Dinners: Short Grocery List, Real Dinner

Simple dinners with five ingredients or fewer.

Cheap Family Dinners With the Cost Per Serving

Learn to estimate cost per serving and stretch a grocery budget.

Easy Dinner Ideas for When You Have No Energy

Low-effort ideas for exhausted nights.

Easy Sheet-Pan Dinners

One-pan dinner formulas, roasting tips and easy combinations.

Freezer Meals for Busy Weeknights

Make-ahead dinner ideas, freezing tips and safe thawing guidance.

Leftover Chicken Recipes

Turn leftover chicken into several easy dinners.

Pantry Staples List for Budget Cooking

Build a practical pantry for affordable meals and less food waste.

Picky-Eater Dinner Ideas That the Whole Table Will Eat

Low-pressure family dinner ideas and practical strategies.

Slow Cooker Dinners for Busy Families

Hands-off slow cooker meals, timing tips and safe food handling.

20 Lazy Dinners for When Your Brain Has Left the Building

Twenty low-effort recipes with prep times and dish counts.

20 Lazy Dinners Sorted by How Tired You Are

Find a dinner that matches your energy level tonight.